Evangelize



HOW MIGHT HOPE COME FROM KNOWING JESUS?

GOSPEL APPOINTMENT

"I AM THE MASTER OF MY FATE, I AND THE CAPTAIN OF MY SOUL."

That is what Henley said in his famous poem *Invictus*.
QUESTION: What do you think of that line? Do you agree or disagree?

If we are the captains of our own souls, we have a lot to carry. One person considered what her life would look like without a relationship with God. She thought writing the opposite meaning of a chapter from the Bible described it well. Read her descriptive poem together, underline or make marks on significant words or phrases, then discuss the questions below.

I lead my own life. There's a lot that I want.

I'm looking for a place to lie in rest, but I can't find it. There's a lot that I worry about, swirling waters all around.

My soul is fragmented. I'm left wandering, not knowing where to go, not knowing right from wrong, living for myself yet going nowhere.

I walk by death all day long, there's a lot that I fear. I feel alone. The comforts I chase after are good only for a short while, then I'm empty inside again.

In the presence of my enemies, I'm put to shame. I feel no blessing, I feel empty inside.

I don't know where good is. I don't know what my final resting place will be. I hope I find it one day.

QUESTION: Which of these statements do you most identify with? What would life look like if that wasn't the case?

Next, do the same thing you did with the above poem with the real one, Psalm 23, on the next page, then discuss the questions below.

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Psalm 23

The LORD is my shepherd, I lack nothing.

He makes me lie down in green pastures, he leads me beside quiet waters, he refreshes my soul.

He guides me along the right paths for his name's sake.

Even though I walk through the darkest valley, I will fear no evil, for you are with me; your rod and your staff, they comfort me.

You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies. You anoint my head with oil; my cup overflows.

Surely your goodness and love will follow me all the days of my life, and I will dwell in the house of the LORD forever.

QUESTION: Since the LORD is another word for the name of Jesus, how might experiencing Jesus as your shepherd be better than you being the captain of your soul?

In another passage of the Bible, John 10:10-11, Jesus says:

"The (devil) comes only to steal and kill and destroy (the sheep); I have come that they may have life, and have it to the full. I am the good shepherd. The good shepherd lays down his life for the sheep."

QUESTION: Do you feel like you have the life that is being stolen, killed and destroyed; or the abundant life as described in Psalm 23? (Consider going back to compare and contrast Psalm 23 and the first version.)

NEXT STEPS:

- What takeaway do you have from thinking about and discussing the passages?
- Have you drawn any new conclusions about your life or who Jesus could be to you?
- For more information on how to receive forgiveness for your sins and receiving Jesus as your "good shepherd" as Lord and Savior - go over the "The Bridge to Life" illustration.

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